

Scare tactics

With its plump body, the eyed hawk moth is a tempting meal for hungry birds. The moth is well camouflaged, but if it is spotted, it has a way of fighting for its life. It suddenly opens up its wings and reveals markings that look like a pair of large, staring eyes. If luck is on its side, the bird hesitates and moves on. This kind of visual trickery is common in insects, and it is also used by some bigger animals, including fish and frogs.



Wing opens to reveal "eye"

Closed wings are well camouflaged

Watch this

Male fiddler crabs live in burrows in mangrove swamps and come out to feed at low tide. Although they are small—often just 1 in (2.5 cm) across—they have one giant claw that they use to signal across the mud. A fiddler crab extends its claw as though it is beckoning and then suddenly flicks it back. This display attracts females and warns rival males away. There are many species of fiddler crab. Each kind has its own signal pattern, so females can find the right type of mate.



Making faces

Most animals cannot make faces because they have little or no muscle to make their faces move. Mammals are different. Some kinds—particularly monkeys and apes—can make a wide range of facial expressions. Their expressions may look like ours, but their meaning isn't always the same. This chimp is making a face called a pout. This is often used as a sign of submission after a fight, but in young chimps it can be a way of begging for food.



Flashing lights

On warm nights, fireflies attract partners by flashing a built-in light. The light is produced on their undersides by a chemical reaction that gives off a yellow or green glow, but almost no heat. The males flash on and off as they fly through the dark. Females flash back, and the males land next to them to mate. Each species has its own coded sequence of flashes, and in some kinds, all the males flash in step.